CHALLENGE 03

A healthy evening ritual

Create a mindful transition from an active day to nighttime rest. The goal is not rigid rules, but repeatable habits that may support relaxation and a regular sleep rhythm.

Wind down gently

A simple evening routine – consistent, relaxed and suited to your own sleep rhythm.

Daily · individual

A possible evening schedule

7:00 pm · last meal

1 hour screen-free

Relax instead of doing more

By 7:00 pm · Dinner

Have your last regular meal in a calm setting and make it balanced. Avoid routine late-night snacking; if you are genuinely hungry later, adjust the timing or portion rather than ignoring hunger.

1 hour before bed · screens off

Put away your phone, tablet and laptop. Dim the lights and choose a quiet activity without constant notifications.

20–30 minutes · relax body and mind

Try gentle yoga, light stretching, breathing exercises or a short meditation. Choose something calming rather than an intense workout.

When you feel sleepy · bedtime

Go to bed at a fairly consistent time and keep a regular wake-up time. Make your bedroom dark, quiet and comfortably cool.

7:00 pm is a guide, not a rule:

Adapt your last meal to your bedtime, daily routine, hunger and any medical needs. A very late or heavy meal may disturb sleep for some people; nobody needs to go to bed hungry.

More tips for a restful evening

Consistency over perfection

Keep bedtimes and wake-up times reasonably consistent, including weekends. Morning daylight helps anchor your body clock.

Cut off caffeine in time

Avoid coffee, energy drinks and caffeinated tea late in the afternoon and evening. Caffeine can remain stimulating for hours.

Don't use alcohol as a sleep aid

Alcohol may make you feel sleepy, but it often reduces sleep quality and makes sleep more fragmented.

Get thoughts out of your head

Write down unfinished tasks or thoughts for tomorrow. A short list can help you mentally switch off.

Prepare your sleep environment

Keep the bedroom dark, quiet and cool. Air it before bed and use an eye mask or earplugs if helpful.

Move during the day

Regular movement and daylight support the sleep–wake rhythm. Try not to schedule very intense sessions immediately before bed.

Evening supplements – what may be useful?

Magnesium

Magnesium is important for normal muscle and nervous-system function. Supplementation may be useful when intake is insufficient. However, evidence that it improves sleep in everyone is not convincing. Consider total intake; higher supplemental amounts can cause diarrhoea and may be problematic with kidney disease or certain medicines.

Glycine

Small human studies using around 3 g of glycine before bedtime report possible improvements in subjective sleep quality. The evidence is still limited and uncertain, so glycine is not an established sleep aid and benefits are not guaranteed.

Melatonin – for a delayed body clock

If your body clock naturally runs significantly later and you struggle to fall asleep at the desired time, a low dose of melatonin (e.g. 1 mg) may be considered short-term with appropriate timing. Timing is crucial; discuss use with a healthcare professional or pharmacist. Its effect is often limited when sleep problems are driven by stress or chronic insomnia – melatonin does not address the underlying cause.

Supplements are not a substitute for healthy sleep habits or assessment of persistent sleep problems. If you take regular medication, have a chronic condition, are pregnant or are unsure, seek medical advice before using them.

> **Important**
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> This challenge is general guidance, not treatment for sleep disorders. If difficulty falling or staying asleep persists, strongly affects your daytime functioning, or is accompanied by loud snoring or breathing pauses, seek medical assessment.

Further reading

- gesund.bund.de – Gut schlafen
- NCCIH – Melatonin: What You Need to Know
- NCCIH – Sleep Disorders and Complementary Health Approaches
- Systematic review – Glycine in human adults (2023)